



The Velocity OF CHANGE

The challenge for the liberal President: Will Islamabad replace Baghdad as the new dateline of American heroism?

By S. Prasannarajan

Barack Hussein Obama..." As he took the oath from the west steps of the Capitol, his left hand placed on the Bible used by Abraham Lincoln on a similar occasion more than a century ago, the words had the resonance of an invocation. On America's day of national catharsis, the words carried within them the cultural diversity—or the civilisational tension—of the world he was going to inherit as the 44th president of the United States. The name in its entirety—a Swahili word with an Arabic origin meaning "blessing", followed by the name of Prophet Mohammad's grandson but for most Americans a name that launched the war in Iraq that undid the 43rd, and ending with a word that separates the new occupant of the White House from Osama by a tenuous consonant—conveys more than the exotic ancestry of the leader of the New World. It also tells us how far America has travelled to reach this moment. Ah, the velocity of hope: "A man whose father less than 60 years ago might not have been served at a local restaurant" stood before around two million people "to take a sacred oath".

The most evocative part of the Inaugural speech was, in an unintended way perhaps, an explanation of the fairy tale journey of

Barack Hussein Obama (born to a Kenyan father from the Luo tribe who was "black as pitch" and a Kansas mother who was "white as milk", brought up in Hawaii and Jakarta, educated at Columbia and Harvard, enlightened by his estranged spiritual mentor Jeremiah "God Damn America" Wright Jr., and hardened by the political machine of Chicago) itself: "We are shaped by every language and culture drawn from every end of this earth; and because we have tasted the bitter swill of civil war and segregation and emerged from that darker chapter stronger and more united, we cannot help but believe that the old hatreds shall someday pass; that the lines of tribe shall soon dissolve; that as the world grows smaller, our common humanity shall reveal itself; and that America must play its role in ushering in a new era of peace."

The optimism is overwhelming, for it is a faith in the future that makes "change" something that "we can believe in". In the beginning, it was a slogan from the sorcerer of mass minds, and a rejoinder to politics-as-usual, which only sharpened partisanship and intensified the culture wars. It was a weapon of mass seduction in a country exhausted by two wars and disillusioned with a president who turned the so-

called Wilsonian internationalism into a moral crusade for freedom on far shores. Candidate Obama was an urbane liberal with the aura of a prophet who was motivated by his own biography, a narrative in inspiring multiculturalism and the audacity of the American Dream. His campaign became a national movement that made "changing" with the phenom a kind of karmic rite. And as president-elect, he breached the fault lines of race and presented himself as the answer to anyone "who still doubts America is a place where all things are possible".

The America that elected him was a place where "the pursuit of happiness" was a dead story. The fear of an economic apocalypse and the anger against an incumbent who made America the safest country on earth after 9/11 but whose biblical project in containing the evil made him one of the most hastily condemned rulers of our times set the stage for a redeemer. Obama spawned a new liberal era, bringing to a definitive end the Conservative high noon that began with Ronald Reagan. FDR redux, rhapsodised the commentariat, and the prospect of a Newer Deal added to the expectations, though the mindset of reducing the gloom in the marketplace to the size of George